car too, along with all the modest luxuries a family needed. Things were going well and I was doing better and better at cricket. And then, suddenly, the markets tanked. Tragedy struck and everything changed overnight.

What hurt me more – more than the beatings I received at the hands of my father – was to see him and my mother sit on the prayer rug and weep at night. Tariq bhai, who was my rock, also broke down often and wondered how we would ever make up for the loss. That was possibly the worst phase we endured as a family. Remember: there were eleven of us. How would my sisters get married? How would we finish our education? Those were some questions to which there weren't any easy answers anymore. As a family, we would never talk about money. But now that the situation was grim, my parents even considered selling our house – and it still wouldn't have been enough. Frankly, we were out of options. I felt the dull stab of uncertainty and poverty as we started rationing our food and cut down our expenses significantly.

Emotionally, our spirits had hit rock bottom, especially when I'd sneak up on my parents and see them weeping, looking heavenwards, asking the Almighty for help. I'd see them do this every night. It broke my heart to hear their sobs. Later, when I'd go and touch the prayer rugs after they were in bed, I'd find them soaked with their tears.

That's when I prayed for just one thing. I prayed to God – all I wanted was to play for Pakistan, if only to help my parents get out of the hell they were in. I was not well schooled and too young to work in an office or anywhere where they would pay me a decent sum. My only hope, for my family and its problems, was to excel at cricket.

Our family's struggle and the phase of uncertainty continued for a few months, and then, just like that, I received a call-up for Pakistan 'A'. And then, soon after, for the Pakistan national team. Life changed overnight. I started believing in the power of prayer and have never stopped since.

I will never forget those days. Never. After all, those were some of the darkest days my family ever saw. We belonged to a humble background and had built a modest existence for ourselves through some years of struggle in Karachi. Losing it all suddenly had really shocked and affected us all. It broke down everything around us – everything except my game.

I didn't let my game be affected. I didn't have the option of failing. When I decided that I would help my family overcome its trauma through cricket, making it to the top of the game became the only option. There was no other choice.

Honestly, my plan was naïve. Those days, there wasn't much money in cricket, even at the highest level. When I eventually made it to the national side in 1996, we were paid around 9,000–10,000 rupees (two hundred US dollars then, around a hundred US dollars now) per game. It wasn't a large sum at the time and I couldn't seriously think that I would dramatically turn around my family's fortunes with my match fees. So it wasn't the cash I was headed for. (That came much later, when the game changed in the new millennium and became more popular and commercialized.)

I was headed for stability. I needed it, my family needed it. I needed to do well for them, especially my father, and not be a burden to him. So I kept on playing – I had no other area of focus, nor did I have any other hopes or aspirations. The only skills I had lay in cricket.

Maybe it was the blind hopefulness and naiveté of being a kid. Maybe it was sheer willpower. But I believed that if God had put me in a crisis, then He would bail me out of it as well. All I